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# A Nation-First Narrative

**Communalism will hurt India's prospects, but the exaggerated portrayal of it by the Opposition will hurt us more. Right now, we need the political discourse to single-mindedly focus on the economy**

**In the 1980s,** Deng Xiaoping, the then supreme leader of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP), decided to focus exclusively on economic development. He realised that for the China dream to come true, the economy, shattered by Mao's decades of defective policies, must be reinvigorated.

The decade saw rapid economic growth and infrastructure development in the country. Foreign investors and technologies were invited into China. When his own colleagues in the party protested, accusing him of promoting capitalist policies, Deng shut them off with the retort that he didn't care about "the colour of the cat as long as it is catching the mice". This ruthless pragmatism, and the courage to set ideologies aside for the larger national good, has helped China reach where it is today.

The developing world is now debating these issues. As James Carville, the campaign strategist for Bill Clinton, quipped in 1992, "It's the economy, stupid." Countries are catching on to Carville's economic mantra, sidestepping ideological hamstrings. Whoever visited the Saudi Arabia pavilion at the recently concluded Expo 2020 Dubai will vouch for the progressive and ultramodern presentation of the mothership of orthodox Islam. Live images of surging race cars with Saudi women at the wheels left every visitor fascinated and flabbergasted. The same is the case with countries in Asia and Africa.

But, sadly, here we are, debating about communal polarisation. Leaders of the Opposition are writing op-eds as if in India, at every street corner, Hindus and Muslims have crossed swords. It may suit the political narrative for some, but it will certainly hurt the country's global narrative at a time when the leadership is steadfastly pursuing an agenda of growth and prosperity for every Indian. No other leadership appreciates this imperative better than the present one. The 2020s will be to India what the 1980s were to China. A decade of singleminded focus on the economy could unleash the country's latent potential and catapult it into the club of developed nations.

Pundits pointing fingers at the central government or some Hindu organisations for this perceived polarisation have a sinister agenda—they want to divert the national discourse by dragging the prime minister's name into it. But the actions of the government speak for its inclusive and development-for-all approach.

Communalism will hurt India's prospects, but the exaggerated portrayal of it will hurt us more. Is the 1.3 billion-strong Indian society really polarised? Should some fringe elements be elevated to the status of 'makers of the national narrative' for a vast country like ours? Isn't it tantamount to, say, calling the entire American society racist just because some truly reprehensible incidents of racial violence happened there?

India's communal problem is centuries old and it continues to erupt occasionally. This may be a kind of whataboutery, but isn't it hubristic on the part of some political leaders to pretentiously argue and take the moral high ground when their own